

CHARLES UNIVERSITY
FACULTY OF SOCIAL SCIENCES

Institute of Political Studies



**Politics, Identity, and Ontological Security
in Bosnia and Herzegovina**

Master's thesis

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Study program: Master's in International Relations

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Year of defense: 2026

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Prague, March 15, 2026

Zachary Alan Stuck

Abstract

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JEL Classification	F12, F21, F23, H25, H71, H87
Keywords	Bosnia, Ontological Security, Identity, Balkan, Machine Learning
Title	Politics, Identity, and Ontological Security in Bosnia and Herzegovina
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Abstrakt

Nutnou součástí práce je anotace, která shrnuje význam práce a výsledky v ní dosažené. Anotace práce by neměla být delší než 200 slov a píše se v jazyce práce (tj. česky, slovensky či anglicky) a v překladu (tj. u anglicky psané práce česky či slovensky, u česky či slovensky psané práce anglicky). Anotace práce by neměla být delší než 200 slov a píše se v jazyce práce (tj. česky, slovensky či anglicky) a v překladu (tj. u anglicky psané práce česky či slovensky, u česky či slovensky psané práce anglicky). V abstraktu by se nemělo citovat.

Klasifikace JEL	F12, F21, F23, H25, H71, H87
Klíčová slova	klicjedna, klicdva, klictri, klicctyri
Název práce	Cenová Elasticita Poptávky po Benzínu: Meta-Analýza
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Acknowledgments

The author is grateful especially to doc. Aliaksei Kazharski, PhD., prof. Lars Hansen, prof. David Zilberman, and participants at several conferences and seminars for their comments. The usual caveat applies.

Slightly modified Chapter 2 has been awarded the Czech Economic Society prize for young authors.

Typeset in FSV L^AT_EX template with great thanks to prof. Zuzana Havrankova and prof. Tomas Havranek of Institute of Economic Studies, Faculty of Social Sciences, Charles University.

Bibliographic Record

stuck, Zachary: *Politics, Identity, and Ontological Security in Bosnia and Herzegovina*. Master's thesis. Charles University, Faculty of Social Sciences, Institute of Political Studies, Prague. 2026, pages 22. Advisor: doc. Aliaksei Kazharski, PhD.

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Acronyms

BiH The Republic of Bosnia and Herzegovina

IR International Relations

Chapter 1

Introduction

This document serves two purposes. First, it is a template and example for a master's thesis. Second, the text in all sections contains some useful information on structuring and writing your thesis.

The introduction should consist of three parts (as paragraphs, not to be structured into multiple headings): The first part deals with the background of the work and describes the field of research. It should also elaborate on the general problem statement and the relevance. The second part should describe the focus of the thesis, typically the paragraph starts with a phrase like “The objective of this thesis is” The last part should describe the structure of the thesis, for instance in the following manner. The thesis is structured as follows: Chapter 2 cites some formal requirements of the faculty, Chapter 3 gives some hints on basic formatting features and covers also acronyms, figures, boxes and tables. Chapter 4 gives a recommendation on the usage of hyphens in English language in $\text{\LaTeX}$ and explains how to use the `itemize` and `quote` environments and shows a few `enumerate`-based environments. Chapter 5 presents a checklist of common mistakes to avoid. Chapter 6 contains numerous hints. Chapter 7 summarizes our findings.

Chapter 2

Theoretical Framework

This thesis conducts analysis under the constructivist paradigm and uses ontological security theory as the understanding for analysis of political speech acts by politicians in The Republic of Bosnia and Herzegovina (BiH). Using this framework allows for a nuanced conceptualization of how political speech acts shape and are shaped by national identities, state actions, ethnic tensions, and other societal factors of state collectives.

2.1 Social Constructivism

Social constructivism provides an International Relations (IR) framework that is largely based on the concept of intersubjectivity—shared meaning and understanding—in society and how various actors influence these meanings and understandings. The primary assumption that constitutes this intersubjectivity is “that people act toward objects, including other actors, on the basis of the meanings that the objects have for them” (Wendt 1992, pg. 396-397). Furthermore, Wendt (1992, pg. 404-405) highlights that actions taken before, during, and after an interaction between actors shapes the meaning of said interaction and how it is understood between them. Despite the relative simplicity of these concepts, they are essential to the constructivist paradigm and allow for the collectivization of meanings and understandings. Building upon these fundamental assumptions, actors and groups of actors are able to create complex societies, interactions, and institutions that constitute modern society, particularly that of governments, states, and the international global order (Wendt 1992, pg. 401-402).

2.1.1 Identity

Identity is fundamental to actors or groups of actors, but they are not limited to one particular identity, but rather multiple identities that are situation dependent. As Wendt (1992, pg. 397) explains, “Actors acquire identities—relatively stable, role-specific understandings and expectations about self—by participating in such collective meanings.” The primary parts of identity, therefore, are an understanding of self and collective meaning under certain circumstances. This can be seen in BiH when discussing *Bosnian* identity and ones *ethnic* identity. Actors often identify as *Bosnian* when interacting with outsiders, but they identify as a particular *ethnic* identity when interacting with other *Bosnians* or members of their collective *ethnic* identities. Contextuality determines many aspects of identity due to its intersubjectivity, and this allows identities to change as context may also change (Wendt 1992, pg. 397-398).

Due to the reliance on roles, identities often overlap, such as someone being both a father and a manager. These two identities are not mutually exclusive, and may be beneficial or detrimental to each other under certain circumstances, but they are both reflections of self expectations and self understanding of one’s roles (Wendt 1992, pg. 397). When applying this to collective identities, such as national identities, ethnic identities, etc., there is a certain role that members of the collective assign to that identity, but also to other identities of a similar collective level (Weldes 1996, pg. 280). These identities require other collective identities of a similar level—nations require other nations—because these identities are “mutually constitutive” (Giddens 1979, as cited in Wendt 1992, pg. 399). Not only are identities formed by internal identification of *self*, but also from external identification that is interpreted by the actor or group of actors who belong to that identity (Todorova 2009, pg. 10-11).

On a national level, identities are formed by the collectivization of people that understand some belonging to a nation, but the identities themselves are shaped by the actions of statesmen (Weldes 1996, pg. 281). National identity is still a collective understanding by the members of the nation, but the norms that form the institution of government provide statesmen with the agency to act and interpret meaning on behalf of the nation (Weldes 1996, pg. 281). This agency provides the grounding for understanding the function that political speech acts in the formation, change, or dissolution of national identities.

2.1.2 Interests

Following the formation of identities, actors form interests that correspond to one or more identities (Wendt 1992, pg. 398). These interests are highly dependent on situations and are motivated by anticipated outcomes of each situation (Wendt 1992, pg. 398), but these interests also serve to reproduce the understood meaning of an actor's identity (Mitzen 2006, pg. 347). These interests come both from the actor's understood meaning of identity, but also as a societal understanding that has become institutionalized, as all social interactions and understanding are inherently intersubjective (Wendt 1992, pg. 398-399; Weldes 1996, pg. 280-281).

Similar to national identities, national interests are also primarily formed by statesmen in alignment with their understanding of the national identity, the situation, and potentially their personal interests (Weldes 1996, pg. 280-282). Weldes (1996, pg. 280) critiqued Wendt's (1992) interpretation of states as unitary actors, and posed that "the meanings which objects, events and actions have for 'states' are necessarily the meanings they have for those individuals who act in the name of the state." This interpretation does not mean that individual citizens of a state or nation do not impact national interests—citizens elect these statesmen in democracies, and protest provide a voice to contest actions made by statesmen—but it puts the primary formation of national interests in statesmen's hands.

2.2 Ontological Security

The use of ontological security in IR research has increased significantly since it was introduced to the field by Kinnvall (2004) and Mitzen (2006), who extended the original application from sociology (Giddens 1991) to states and international actors. Ontological security relies on actors maintaining consistent identities, routines, trust, and other cognitive and social structures, which are often considered making up the *security of being* (Kinnvall & Mitzen 2020, pg. 240). Giddens (1991) focused on the ontological security of individuals, particularly the experiences of individuals and how they shape one's understanding of themselves. As Mitzen (2006, pg. 352) poses, a similar approach to analyzing *the security of being* can be applied to states as collective units formed by societal interactions and understanding. Ontological security in IR expands upon the paradigm of social constructivism by applying Giddens's (1991) understanding

of routines, trust, self to the state level (Mitzen 2006; Kinnvall 2004). This expansion constructed an analytical framework that provides an understanding of ontological security and insecurity, as well as the ability of states to form interests and take actions with an inherent interest to maintain ontological security and reduce uncertainty (Mitzen 2006; Kinnvall 2004).

2.2.1 Identity

Similar to traditional social constructivism, identities motivate actors' interests, actions, and understandings, but ontological security expands the role of identity and poses that actors are motivated to maintain stable identities to feel ontologically secure (Mitzen 2006, pg. 344-345). The literature on ontological security also expands upon the formation of identities, particularly group identities by highlighting how humans understand *self* and *self-differentiation* (Kinnvall 2004, pg. 749-750) Kinnvall (2004, pg. 749-752) poses that self-identification inherently requires a *subject other*, and he debates the difference between categorization, both internally and externally, and membership regarding the role of societal groups in identity formation. Furthermore, Kinnvall (2004, pg. 751-752) combines securitization with the subjectivity of *other* to describe how both an actor's self-identity and subjective understanding of the *other* are securitized to maintain a cohesive interpretation of society and the environment.

The way that identities are essential to their securitization and to the securitization of the self. In Kinnvall's construction of ontological security, the concept of *abjection*—"unconscious self is neither an object nor a subject" (Kinnvall 2004, pg. 753)—is a way to reduce uncertainty and increase ontological security, both for individuals and collectives (Kinnvall 2004, pg. 753-754). This unconscious state of abjection is a primary method for mitigating change, but it leads to the creation of collective identity "when the familiar 'stranger' is suddenly recognized as a threat" (Kinnvall 2004, pg. 753). This can be seen clearly in BiH following the collapse of Yugoslavia and reemergence of ethnic identities that were weaponized to insight the ethnic conflicts in the 1990s. The dichotomy between self and other that leads to the creation of or membership to identities is particularly evident and destructive when the differences between self and other become ambiguous (Norton 1988, as cited in Kinnvall 2004, pg. 753).

This rather psychological approach to the formation of identity highlights the importance of maintaining ontological security and reducing the ambiguities

of the self. When actors are unsure of who they are or what is to come, they often turn to membership or creation of identities driven by fear or hatred of the *other* rather than the simple dichotomous classification between self and “stranger other” (Kinnvall 2004, pg.754 755). This formation of enemies is what leads to racism, anti-Semitism, ethnic conflicts, genocides, and conflict in general. This is not to say that ontological insecurity guarantees the formation of ‘enemies,’ but it does increase the chances of these classifications forming.

2.2.2 Routines & Trust

2.2.3 Nationalism & National Identity

Chapter 3

History & Context

Chapter 4

Methodological Framework

Chapter 5

Data

Chapter 6

Empirical Analysis

Chapter 7

Conclusion

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Appendix B

Content of Enclosed DVD

This is optional: you may enclose a DVD to this thesis which contains empirical data and MatLab/R/Stata source codes. Even better so, you can create a special website for your project. Stating in your thesis that the data and source codes are available upon request is enough but please, have them prepared for such requests.

- Folder 1: Source codes
- Folder 2: Empirical data